Latvia — Land, People and Origins

THE LAND

- Latvia (64,589 km²) lies on the Baltic Sea between Estonia and Lithuania. Its name comes from the ancient Baltic tribe of the Latgallians.
- Rivers — above all the Daugava (1,020 km) — forests (about half the country) and a 531 km coastline have shaped life, trade and defence for a thousand years.
- Amber from the Baltic coast, the “gold of the North”, linked Latvia to the Roman Empire and the Silk Road more than 2,000 years ago.

THE PEOPLE AND THE LANGUAGE

- Latvians speak Latvian, one of only two surviving Baltic languages (with Lithuanian) of the Indo-European family — a sister group to Slavic and Germanic.
- The Latvian nation formed from Baltic tribes — Latgallians, Curonians, Semigallians — with Finnic Livonian neighbours.
- Population today: about 1.9 million; the largest city is Riga (~605,000), founded in 1201.



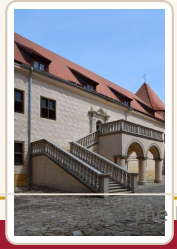
Riga, the capital, at sunset (illustration)

FROM ANCIENT TRIBES TO A MODERN STATE — THE ROAD IN BRIEF

- **c. 3000 BC** — Baltic tribes arrive
- **12th c.** — Crusaders found Riga (1201)
- **1561** — Livonian Confederation ends
- **1629–1710** — Swedish rule
- **1710–1918** — Russian Empire
- **1918** — Republic proclaimed 18 Nov
- **1940–91** — Soviet occupation
- **2004** — Joins EU and NATO







Sources: Encyclopaedia Britannica; Latvian Institute; Wikimedia Commons (CC); illustrations generated for this deck.

Centuries of Change: 13th–20th Century

MEDIEVAL LIVONIA (1200S–1561)

- The Livonian Brothers of the Sword bring Christianity; Riga is founded in 1201 and joins the Hanseatic League — one of northern Europe's great trading cities.
- Teutonic Knights, bishops and Riga's merchants shape Terra Mariana (“Land of Mary”). Castles such as Cēsis, Turaida and Bauska rise across the land.
- The Reformation (1520s–30s) makes Livonia Lutheran; the Livonian Confederation crumbles in the Livonian War (1558–1583).

POLISH–LITHUANIAN AND SWEDISH RULE (1561–1721)

- The Duchy of Courland (1561) becomes a thriving vassal of Poland–Lithuania, with a fleet that even colonised Tobago (1642).
- Under Sweden (1629–1710) Riga's trade booms; the Great Northern War (1700–1721) devastates the land and brings it under Russia.

IN THE RUSSIAN EMPIRE (1721–1918)

- Serfdom abolished in Courland (1817) and Livonia (1819). The National Awakening (from the 1850s) revives language and song: the first Song Festival, Riga 1873.
- Industrialisation and railways grow Riga into the Empire's third city; the 1905 Revolution is violently suppressed.
- WWI brings front lines and 700,000 Latvian Riflemen; the Russian collapse opens the way to independence.

INDEPENDENCE AND OCCUPATION (1918–1991)

- **18 Nov 1918** The Republic of Latvia is proclaimed in Riga; a war of independence (1918–1920) secures it against Soviet Russia and German forces.
- The interwar republic flourishes — democracy, land reform, education — while caught between Nazi Germany and Stalin's USSR (Molotov–Ribbentrop Pact, 1939).
- **1940–41, 1944–91** Two Soviet occupations: the deportations of 14 June 1941 and 25 March 1949 send ~94,000 Latvians to Siberia; forced collectivisation and Russification follow.
- Nazi German occupation (1941–44) brings the Holocaust: ~70,000 Latvian Jews are murdered.
- **1987–1991** The Singing Revolution: the Baltic Way human chain of 23 Aug 1989 (2 million people, 600 km) restores independence, de facto on 21 Aug 1991.



Medieval Hanseatic Riga on the Daugava (illustration)



Proclamation, 18 Nov 1918 (illustration)



The Baltic Way, 23 Aug 1989 (illustration)

Sources: Encyclopaedia Britannica; Latvian History (Latvian Institute); USHMM. Illustrations generated for this deck.

Independence Restored & Latvia Today

RESTORED INDEPENDENCE AND TODAY

- **1991–2004** Independence restored (21 Aug 1991); Soviet troops leave by 1994; Latvia joins the EU and NATO in 2004 and the eurozone in 2014.
- Today Latvia is a stable parliamentary republic of ~1.9 million people. Riga's Old Town is a UNESCO World Heritage site; the country leads in digital government.
- Latvia stands with Ukraine: since 2022 it has hosted tens of thousands of refugees and is among Ukraine's strongest supporters.
- Flag: carmine red (“Latvian red”) with a white stripe — one of the world's oldest flags, legend says born from a blood-stained battlefield banner.

THE SONG AND DANCE FESTIVAL

- First held in 1873, the Latvian Song and Dance Celebration gathers up to ~40,000 singers and dancers; listed by UNESCO in 2003 as Intangible Cultural Heritage.
- Songs carried the nation through 50 years of occupation — singing was an act of quiet resistance.



Freedom Monument, Riga — “Milda”, 1935 (photo: Wikimedia Commons)



Modern Riga at dusk (illustration)



June 1941 deportations — remembered (illustration)



Latvian Song and Dance Celebration 2023 (photo: Wikimedia Commons, CC)

KEY FACTS

Capital: Riga (founded 1201) • Area: 64,589 km² • Population: ~1.9 M

Language: Latvian (Baltic, Indo-European) • Currency: euro (€) since 2014

Government: parliamentary republic • EU & NATO member since 2004

UNESCO: Historic Centre of Riga; Struve Geodetic Arc; Song Festival tradition

Sources: Encyclopaedia Britannica; UNESCO; Latvian Ministry of Foreign Affairs; Wikimedia Commons (CC). Illustrations generated for this deck.